GEC1044 Chinese Medicine: Theory and Practice



Final Project (Individual)【30%】

Improving the physical and mental health of university students

A Pattern-Based Food Therapy Approach to Nourishment and Everyday Student Wellbeing

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Name	**Student ID**
Lou Yu	A0244992R

1 Introduction

Periods of depression and limited physical activity taught me how low energy complicates daily tasks. This motivated a meal that students could prepare with simple equipment and manageable effort. Chinese yam, lotus seed and red date congee addresses fatigue, poor appetite, disturbed sleep and academic stress through course-based pattern reasoning adapted to student routines.

This analysis combines course knowledge of Chinese medicine and dietary therapy with psychology and IE2141 Systems Thinking and Dynamics. Figure 1 records pulse-position teaching at Thong Chai. Lecture 7 interprets pulse findings alongside symptoms, emotions, constitution, routines and environment; Lecture 9 extends this holistic assessment to matching food properties with the individual's presentation (GEC1044 2026). These principles guide the report's sequence: assess the whole presentation, identify the dietary aim and select ingredients.

System modelling then connects stress, sleep, fatigue and preparation demands to explore how the recipe fits students' routines (Sterman 2000).

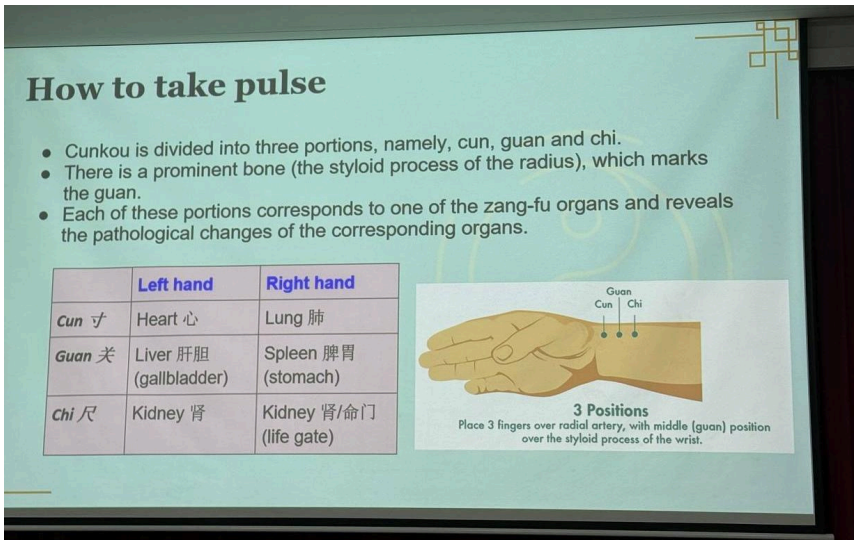


Figure 1. Pulse positions explained during the Thong Chai teaching session. Photograph by the author.

2 Understanding the health concerns

2.1 A Chinese medicine perspective

Lecture 7 distinguishes individual symptoms from Zheng (pattern/syndrome, 证型). Inspection, listening and smelling, inquiry, and palpation bring signs together before a treatment principle is selected.

Fatigue together with poor appetite suggests investigating Spleen Qi deficiency (脾气虚). Within Chinese medicine, the Spleen and Stomach receive and transform food; reduced nourishment gives a traditional explanation for linking eating poorly with low energy. Inquiry would therefore cover meal regularity, stool consistency and whether tiredness persists after rest. The practitioner would also examine the tongue and pulse.

When fatigue and poor appetite accompany interrupted sleep, palpitations and pallor, assessment would consider Heart-Spleen deficiency (心脾两虚). A Chinese University of Hong Kong booklet describes this cluster with loose stools and a pale tongue (官可祈 n.d., 9). Its audience is young cancer survivors; this report borrows the pattern description for its student scenario. The Heart's association with Shen (神), or mental and emotional activity, connects sleep with digestive nourishment.



Figure 2(a). Qi deficiency and dietary matching: the board lists rice, yam and red dates as nourishing food choices. Adapted from Hong Kong Department of Health, Chinese Medicine Regulatory Office (n.d.-b).



Figure 2(b). Contrasting guidance for damp-heat and phlegm-dampness illustrates the importance of matching dietary choices to the presentation. Adapted from Hong Kong Department of Health, Chinese Medicine Regulatory Office (n.d.-b).

Academic stress connects these digestive and sleep concerns. Lecture 10 distinguishes ordinary emotions from prolonged or excessive emotional strain within the TCM framework, where Heart and Spleen describe functional systems. The HKU School of Chinese Medicine explains that excessive brooding can constrain Qi and impair the Spleen's transformation of food, linking reduced appetite and bloating with diminished nourishment and energy (蔡穎輝 2017). For students worried about deadlines, assessment therefore brings eating, energy and mental rest into the same discussion. Following this logic, the corresponding food therapy (食疗) principle is to support the Spleen and nourish the body while including ingredients traditionally used to calm Shen (神).

Comparing this pattern with alternative presentations clarifies the recipe's intended role. The University of Hong Kong associates Liver fire insomnia with irritability, and phlegm heat with

gastric bloating, heavy-headedness and a bitter taste in the mouth (梁頌然 2022). Such cases call for heat-clearing or phlegm-resolving approaches. Lecture 9 similarly emphasises matching food properties to the individual's pattern. In contrast, this recipe adopts a tonifying approach targeted at Spleen Qi deficiency and Heart-Spleen deficiency. Applying this principle also requires consideration of students' daily routines and ongoing emotional strain.

2.2 Psychology and recipe usability

Building on the TCM connection between digestion, rest and emotional strain, a biopsychosocial perspective relates academic pressure and rumination to disrupted sleep, poor appetite and fatigue, which can reduce energy for study and cooking (Hooley, Nock, and Butcher 2021). Figure 3 visualises these interacting influences.

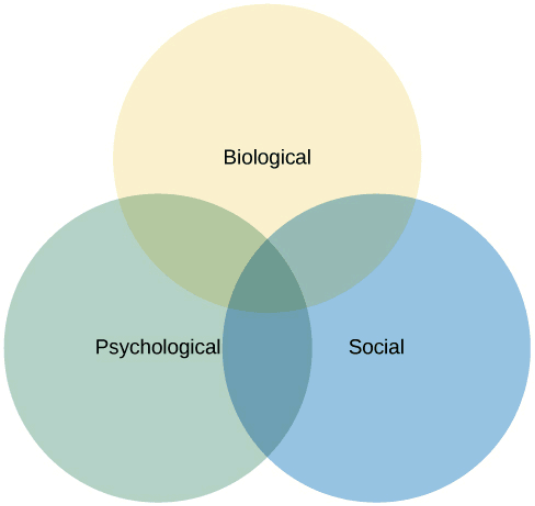


Figure 3. Biopsychosocial model (Spielman, Jenkins, and Lovett 2020, fig. 1.15; CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). Reproduced unchanged; the surrounding discussion applies it to students.

Behavioural activation favours achievable starting tasks (Cacioppo, Freberg, and Cacioppo 2022). One saucepan, familiar ingredients and two planned portions reduce preparation barriers while producing a tangible result. Cooking interventions also offer opportunities for engagement alongside nutrition (Farmer, Touchton-Leonard, and Ross 2018). This biopsychosocial framework connects students' coexisting fatigue, sleep and appetite concerns while providing a behavioural rationale for an accessible food-therapy design.

2.3 Acupuncture as an additional care option

Beyond food therapy, acupuncture offers an additional option following professional assessment. Lecture 8's reinforcing-deficiency and reducing-excess principles apply the same pattern-guided reasoning as dietary selection (GEC1044 2026). The congee emphasises gentle nourishment for the proposed deficiency patterns; stagnation or excess presentations require different intervention choices. Acupuncture also has applications to deficiency, with treatment selected individually. Figure 4 records acupuncture safety precautions from the Thong Chai teaching session, illustrating the standard safeguards that accompany individualised pattern-based treatment.

Acupuncture requires a registered practitioner holding a valid practising certificate (Ministry of Health 2026). These principles connect the preceding assessment to the recipe developed below.



Figure 4. Acupuncture teaching at Thong Chai. The slide records precautions; the discussion of individualized treatment draws on Lecture 8. Photograph by the author.

3 The recipe and its ingredients

3.1 Chinese yam, lotus seed and red date congee (山药莲子红枣粥)

The starting point is the Hong Kong Department of Health's yam and red date congee: 200 g yam and 30 g red dates with rice (n.d.-a). My version adds lotus seeds, halves the dates for lighter sweetness, and specifies rice and water for repeatable preparation.

The proposed batch makes two portions. All quantities below are planned kitchen weights. Fresh yam and dried ingredients are listed separately because their weights and preparation differ.

Table 1. Planned ingredients for two portions

Ingredient	Planned weight	Per portion (half batch)	Specification
Chinese yam 山药	200 g	100 g	Fresh peeled edible portion
Lotus seeds 莲子	20 g	10 g	Dried shelled seeds with green embryos removed
Red dates 红枣	15 g	7.5 g	Dried pitted edible portion
Japonica rice (粳米)	80 g	40 g	Dry, uncooked japonica rice
Water	1,000 ml	500 ml (planned)	Starting amount; add if needed during cooking

3.2 From pattern to food therapy (理—法—方—食)

The design moves from pattern explanation (li, 理), to dietary principle (fa, 法), combination (fang, 方), and preparation (shi, 食). For Spleen Qi and Heart-Spleen deficiency, it aims to strengthen the Spleen and replenish Qi (健脾益气), with nourishment of the Heart and calming Shen (养心安神) for unsettled sleep. Lecture 9's medicine and food sharing a common origin (药食同源) guides this selection. Gui Pi Tang (归脾汤), a classical medicinal formula, similarly combines Spleen support with Heart nourishment (Hong Kong Baptist University n.d.). This congee adapts that therapeutic direction into everyday food, while medicinal treatment remains individually prescribed.

Design pathway (author's application of Lecture 9)

理: Pattern	→	法: Principle	→	方: Combination	→	食: Preparation
Spleen Qi / Heart-Spleen deficiency		Support Spleen; calm Shen		Yam, lotus seeds, dates, rice		Two-portion congee

3.3 Ingredient properties and roles

Chinese yam, shan yao (山药), supplies the digestive foundation. The Hong Kong Polytechnic University (PolyU) describes dried yam rhizome as sweet and neutral, with Spleen, Lung and Kidney affinities and functions supporting the Spleen and Stomach (Hong Kong Polytechnic University n.d.-d). The fresh-yam target follows the Department of Health's recipe.

Lotus seed, lian zi (莲子), links digestive nourishment with mental rest. PolyU lists a sweet and astringent flavour, neutral nature, and Spleen, Kidney and Heart affinities; supporting the Spleen and calming Shen explains its addition to yam (Hong Kong Polytechnic University n.d.-b). The batch uses 20 g dried, shelled seeds without green embryos.

Red dates, da zao (大枣/红枣), support nourishment and sweetness. Their warm, sweet nature and Spleen–Stomach affinities accompany traditional functions of supplementing middle Qi, nourishing blood and calming Shen (Hong Kong Polytechnic University n.d.-a). The planned 15 g per batch limits sweetness. Two whole red dates produced mild sweetness without added sugar. Omitting added sugar retained flavour while limiting added sugar intake; naturally occurring sugars still affect blood glucose and should be considered by people with diabetes (Health Promotion Board n.d.-b).

Northeast japonica rice (粳米) already available at home provides the congee base. Zhou's dietary teaching classifies japonica rice as neutral and sweet, entering the Spleen and Stomach (周玉弦 n.d., 27). Lecture 9's white/Metal–Lung correspondence is a separate framework. Its traditional nourishing role complements a soft, filling meal; other rice varieties may be used with water and timing adjusted.

Table 2. Traditional ingredient properties and roles

Figure 5. Reference images: dried yam, lotus seeds, red dates and Northeast rice

Ingredient	Nature and flavour	Traditional affinity	Role in this congee
Chinese yam 	Neutral and sweet	Spleen, Lung, Kidney	Appetite and fatigue: main digestive and nourishing focus
Lotus seed 	Neutral, sweet and astringent	Spleen, Kidney, Heart	Appetite and sleep: links digestive support with calming Shen
Red date 	Warm and sweet	Spleen, Stomach	Nourishment and flavour: natural sweetness; 15 g per batch, no added sugar
Northeast japonica rice (东北大米/粳米) 	Neutral and sweet	Spleen, Stomach; white/Metal–Lung correspondence in Lecture 9	Traditionally nourishes Spleen–Stomach; congee base, food carrier, soft texture and satiety

My Thong Chai photograph shows the framework applied here (Figure 6): nature, flavour, meridian affinity and function are separate questions about each ingredient.

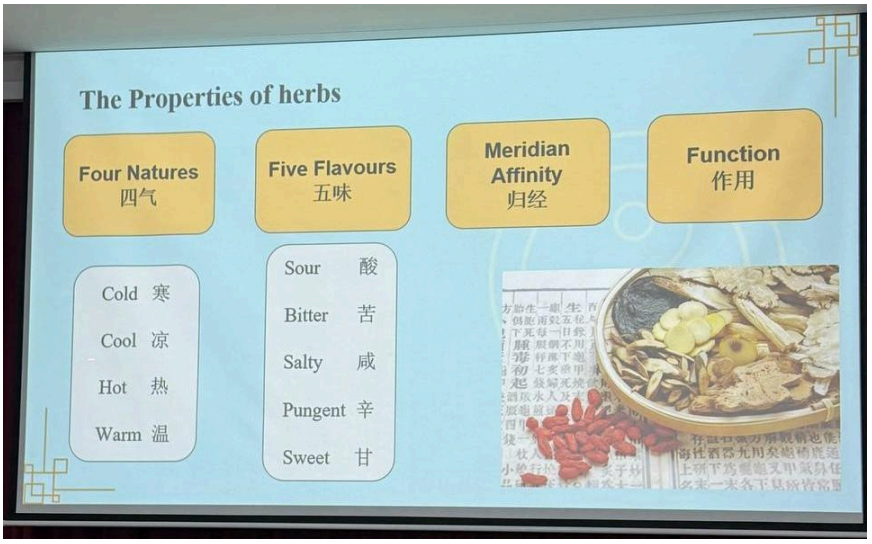


Figure 6. A teaching slide on the properties of herbs at Thong Chai. Photograph by the author.

3.4 Combination and design logic

Using Lecture 9's jun–chen–zuo–shi (君臣佐使) framework, this design assigns yam the chief (jun) role: its Spleen-supporting function addresses the central appetite–fatigue concern. Lotus seed is the deputy (chen), reinforcing that digestive aim while extending the combination toward calming Shen. Dates act as assistant (zuo), adding nourishment and balancing flavour; rice is the carrier (shi), turning the ingredients into a familiar meal. These are the project's design roles, applied to a food combination.

The four ingredients cover digestive nourishment and mental rest within a manageable food recipe. Removing the bitter, cold lotus embryo matches its nourishing direction and mild flavour (Hong Kong Polytechnic University n.d.-c). Earlier Tong Keow fieldwork linked lighter qing bu (清补) preferences to Singapore's humid climate; this recipe likewise favours gentle nourishment, with individual pattern matching guiding selection.

4 Home preparation and practical evaluation

4.1 Cooking reference and preparation plan

The cooking method is adapted from Fu Rui Geng's (福瑞羹) Douyin video "家里常煮的养胃粥，食材普通又温和" (2026; Figure 7). The recipe specifies 60 g rice, 30 g yam, 15 g lotus seeds and two red dates.

The video soaks lotus seeds until soft, combines the four ingredients in one pot and simmers for about 30 minutes, using dates for sweetness without added sugar.

The trial followed this sequence using Section 3's planned two-portion quantities, with actual adjustments recorded in Section 4.5.



(a) Congee presentation on Douyin



(b) Ingredient preparation on Douyin

Figure 7. Fu Rui Geng (福瑞羹)'s Douyin video: (a) congee presentation; (b) ingredient preparation. Screenshots supplied by the author.

4.2 Ingredient purchase and preliminary cost

The ingredients in Figure 8 were purchased from two local retailers. Giant supplied fresh Chinese yam; Bee's Brand Bird Nest & Health Product Pte Ltd (蜂标燕窝保健品私人有限公司) supplied Xinjiang Ruoqiang pitted red dates (新疆若羌去核红枣) and skinless Hunan Xiang lotus seeds (去皮湖南湘莲子).

The Bee's Brand outlet was at Block 19, Ghim Moh Road #01-251. Package weights and prices are recorded below, with photographs documenting ingredient selection and purchase.



(a) Chinese yam (山药)

600 g • S$3.37

Giant



(b) Pitted Ruoqiang dates

若羌去核红枣

500 g • S$4.00

Bee's Brand



(c) Skinless Hunan lotus seeds

去皮湖南湘莲子

250 g • S$5.80

Bee's Brand

Figure 8. Ingredient-purchase photographs: (a) Chinese yam at Giant; (b) pitted red dates; (c) skinless lotus seeds, centre packet. Photographs supplied by the author.

The packs cost S$13.17; rice was available at home. Allocating pack prices to the planned quantities gives approximately S$1.71 per batch or S$0.85 per portion. This preliminary estimate covers the core purchased ingredients only, excluding rice, water, energy and preparation losses; it is a reference allocation rather than the measured cost of the trial.

4.3 Preparation method

For this recipe, use a saucepan with a lid, a kitchen scale and a measuring jug. Use the planned rice and lotus seed quantities with the tested 175 g peeled yam and two red dates. Rinse the lotus seeds and follow the packet's soaking instructions, checking that the green embryos have been removed. Wash the rice. Peel the yam with gloves if its sap irritates the skin, then cut it into small pieces. Wash and pit the dates.

Students who prefer to avoid peeling fresh yam can consider packaged dehydrated yam slices, such as Bee's Brand's Dehydrated Rhizoma Dioscoreae (正河南脱水淮山片). Confirm the dry quantity and soaking requirements with the supplier or a registered TCM practitioner, and follow the product's refrigeration instructions. Dried yam requires a separate weight from the recipe's 200 g fresh-yam target (Bee's Brand Bird Nest & Health Product Pte Ltd n.d.-a).

For the revised method, place the prepared rice, lotus seeds, yam and dates in the saucepan with 1,200 ml water, following the trial's adjustment from the original 1,000 ml plan. Heat until boiling, then reduce to a gentle simmer. Keep the lid slightly ajar, stir occasionally, and cook until the rice opens and the yam and lotus seeds soften. Switch off the heat and rest the congee under a closed lid for five minutes before serving. Section 4.5 records the observed timing and result.

Cool any saved portion quickly, ideally within one hour, refrigerate, and use within 24 hours; reheat once until steaming hot throughout (Food Standards Agency 2026).

4.4 Serving and suitability

Serve one portion warm, initially once or twice weekly, adjusting to tolerance and routine. Planned portions provide 10 g lotus seeds and 7.5 g dates, within HSA's 6–15 g daily medicinal reference ranges for single-ingredient Chinese proprietary medicines (Health Sciences Authority 2025, entries 95 and 230). For this everyday food recipe, the comparison informs quantity screening, not an efficacy dose or a guarantee of safety. Account for allergies and prescribed diets; fresh and dried yam require separate weights. Persistent symptoms warrant professional assessment.

For those with diabetes or prediabetes, including middle-aged and older users, some white rice may be swapped for higher-fibre whole grains such as millet (小米), oats or brown rice. Portion size and cooking style remain important considerations: these grains still contain carbohydrates, and lengthy cooking can amplify the glycaemic response. Adjust serving sizes to align with the individual's dietary plan and blood glucose results (HealthHub n.d.-a n.d.-b).

4.5 Cooking trial and user feedback

Peeling losses reduced the fresh yam's edible weight to 175 g. The trial used two red dates, reported as approximately matching the planned 15 g, to retain mild sweetness. Water increased from 1,000 to 1,200 ml to sustain simmering and reduce sticking; low heat and a vented lid controlled boil-over. Table 1 records the initial design; the tested version below is the practical starting recipe.

(1) Add two complete 600 ml bottles of water (1,200 ml total) and heat on high for about five minutes.

(2) As bubbling approaches the rim, reduce to low heat and leave the lid slightly ajar to reduce boil-over (Figure 9(b)). Simmer for 30–40 minutes until thickened (Figure 9(c)).

(3) Switch off the heat, remove the chopstick used to prop the lid, close the lid and rest for five minutes. Total heating and resting time was about 40–50 minutes.



Figure 9(a). Prepared ingredients and two 600 ml bottles of water. Photograph by the author.

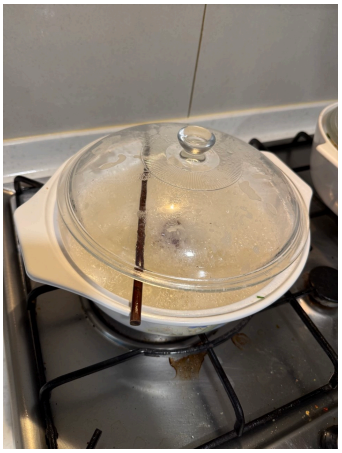


Figure 9(b). Gentle simmering with the lid held slightly open. Photograph by the author.

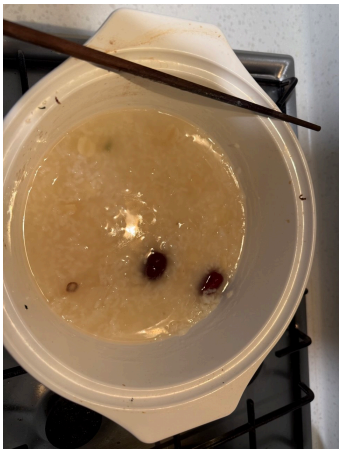


Figure 9(c). Thickened congee before the covered rest. Photograph by the author.



Figure 10(a). Finished congee served in a bowl after the covered rest. Photograph by the author.



Figure 10(b). Another view of the finished congee, showing rice, lotus seeds and a red date. Photograph by the author.

The batch produced two servings (Figure 10). Yam and lotus seeds were tender, the consistency balanced and the flavour mildly sweet from two red dates, without added sugar. My mother and cousin reported comfortable fullness and no immediate bloating. These observations support initial culinary acceptability and a preference for lightly sweetened food.

While the consistency from this trial was satisfactory, future iterations could aim for a richer texture by reducing water to 1,000–1,100 ml, adding weighed extra dates and extending simmering time. A one-to-two-week tracking diary could use a 1–5 rating scale to record preparation burden, appetite, energy levels and sleep quality, alongside notes on tolerance and routine adherence.

To explore how this recipe fits students' wider wellbeing routines, an exploratory system dynamics model illustrates hypothetical trade-offs between self-care benefits and preparation burden.

5 Reflection and conclusion

5.1 Modelling approach and results

An exploratory system dynamics model connects stress, sleep, fatigue, traditional functional states and cooking demands (Lou 2026; Sterman 2000). Its outcomes depend on theoretical parameter assumptions rather than observed food-therapy effects. Within this hypothetical comparison, basic lifestyle improvements contribute more to physical and mental wellbeing than adding congee alone. More frequent consumption also increases preparation demands, making personal energy and available time central to a sustainable routine. Figure 11 illustrates this exploratory comparison.

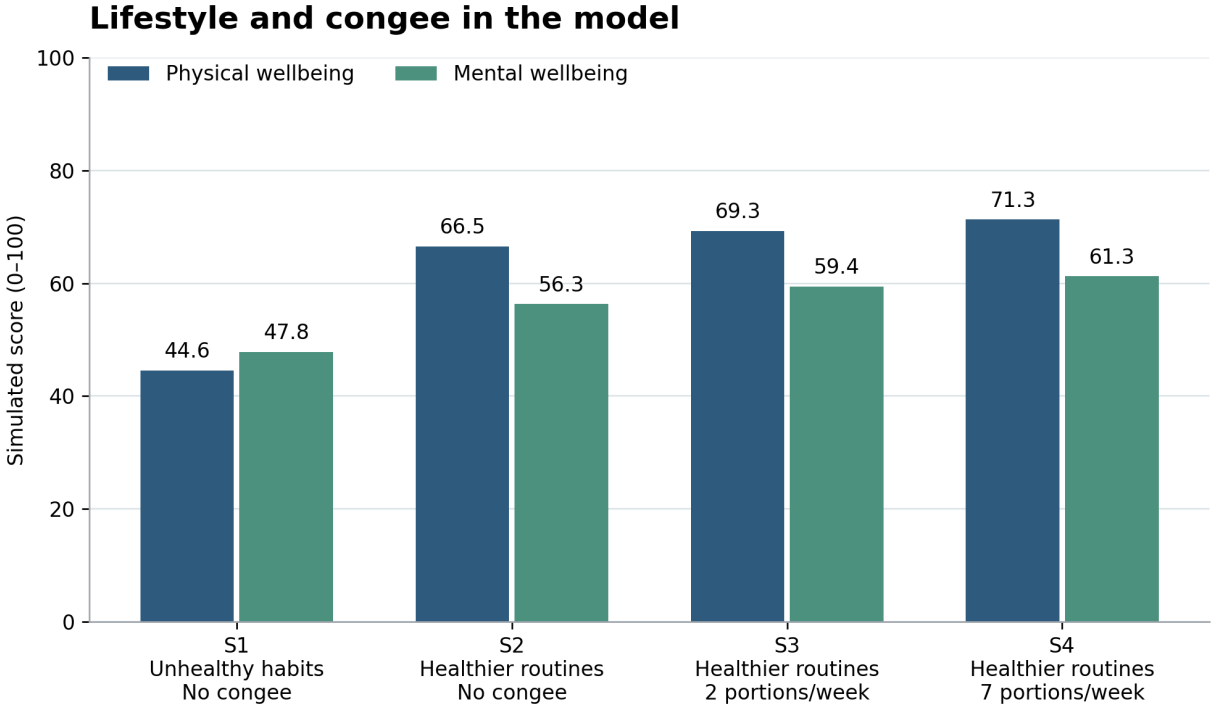


Figure 11. Exploratory comparison of lifestyle and congee scenarios (Lou 2026). Results are hypothetical and based on theoretical parameter assumptions.

5.2 Conclusions drawn from the model

The exploratory comparison places food therapy within broader yangsheng (养生): regular meals, rest, emotional balance and suitable activity. For planning, a two-person batch takes an estimated 75 minutes including preparation, cooking and cleaning: two portions require 1.25 hours weekly, while seven portions require 3.5 batches, or approximately 4.38 hours. The recorded 40–50 minutes covers heating and covered resting only. This arithmetic describes a preparation budget, supporting a manageable schedule rather than a prescribed consumption frequency.

Preparing the congee myself turned the course's account of everyday yangsheng into a practical task. Washing ingredients, monitoring the simmer and cleaning afterwards showed me that even a simple meal requires planning when energy is limited. This experience clarified why I chose familiar ingredients, one saucepan and two portions: accessibility depends on the whole preparation process, not merely the number of ingredients. It also changed how I understand pattern-guided food therapy. The recipe provides a starting point that can be adjusted to appetite, tolerance, available time and preferred texture. Sustained dietary care therefore involves observing everyday responses and adapting the routine, bringing the course's principle of matching food to the individual into ordinary life.

5.3 Overall conclusion

This project links pattern-guided ingredient selection to a palatable meal with low-effort preparation. Its gentle sweetness, satisfying satiety and refined cooking process make it suitable for integration into a healthy daily routine. The supporting evidence falls into three tiers: TCM properties supply the traditional theoretical basis, the simulation investigates hypothesised interactions, and tasting feedback establishes initial culinary acceptability. Clinical benefits and individual suitability still require professional evaluation.

Consistent hydration, such as lukewarm water if preferred, forms part of everyday self-care (NHS 2023). Students with low physical stamina should start with gentle to moderate activity and avoid strenuous exercise that worsens fatigue; medical advice should be sought before raising exercise intensity (Health Promotion Board n.d.-a). Acupuncture, as an optional intervention, demands personalised assessment by a registered practitioner holding a valid practising certificate (Lecture 8; Ministry of Health 2026).

For serious psychological distress, contact the national mindline 1771 immediately. For persistent physical symptoms, consult both a registered TCM practitioner and a general practitioner. The congee should not be used as a standalone intervention.

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